title: "Pets and Animals Policy" version: "1.0" effectiveDate: "[Insert Date]" reviewDate: "[Insert Date – usually annually]" appliesTo: "All residents, staff, contractors, volunteers, and visitors at [INSERT CARE HOME NAME]"

Pets and Animals Policy

Policy Title: Pets and Animals Policy
Effective Date: [Insert Date]
Review Date: [Insert Date – usually annually]
Version: 1.0
Applies to: All residents, staff, contractors, volunteers, and visitors at [INSERT CARE HOME NAME]

1. Policy Statement

At [INSERT CARE HOME NAME], we recognise the benefits that pets and visiting animals can bring to residents' wellbeing, including companionship, comfort, and emotional support. We are committed to enabling safe and positive interactions with animals while ensuring the safety, dignity, and health of all residents, staff, and visitors.

We aim to:

- Encourage animal interaction where it enhances quality of life
- Ensure pets and animals are introduced in a safe, controlled manner
- Minimise risks relating to infection, allergies, and injury
- Comply with health, safety, and infection control requirements

2. Purpose

This policy sets out:

- Rules for residents keeping personal pets within the home
- Arrangements for visiting animals (e.g., therapy pets, family pets)
- Risk management measures to safeguard residents and staff
- Responsibilities for care, hygiene, and supervision of animals

3. Scope

This policy applies to:

- Residents who wish to keep or have visits from pets
- Visitors and families bringing animals into the home
- External organisations providing therapy or support animals

- Staff responsible for facilitating animal interactions

4. Roles and Responsibilities

Registered Manager:

- Approves the presence of pets within the care home
- Ensures risk assessments are completed for resident pets or visiting animals
- Oversees infection prevention and health and safety measures

Staff:

- Support residents in caring for their pets where appropriate
- Ensure animals are handled safely and supervised at all times
- Report concerns, incidents, or allergies related to animals

Residents and Families:

- Must comply with rules and risk assessments relating to pet ownership or visits
- Remain responsible for the behaviour and welfare of their animals

External Organisations (e.g., therapy pet providers):

- Must provide proof of vaccinations, health checks, and insurance for animals visiting the home

5. Pets in Residence

- Residents may keep a personal pet only with prior approval from the Registered Manager and following a risk assessment.
- Considerations will include the resident's ability to care for the pet, impact on other residents, allergies, infection risks, and space requirements.
- Pets must be well-behaved, house-trained, and not pose a risk to others.
- Veterinary care, vaccinations, flea/worm treatment, and grooming must be maintained at the owner's/family's expense.
- In the event that a resident is unable to care for their pet, alternative arrangements will be made with family or external organisations.

6. Visiting Animals

- Visiting animals (including family pets) must be agreed in advance with the care home.
- Animals must be clean, vaccinated, and under control (e.g., on a lead, in a carrier).
- Visits must take place in designated areas unless risk assessed otherwise.
- Staff may restrict animal visits where residents have allergies, phobias, or health risks.

7. Therapy and Support Animals

- Therapy or support animals may be invited into the care home through recognised organisations.
- Proof of vaccinations, health status, and liability insurance must be provided.
- Therapy animals must be supervised at all times and interactions tailored to residents' needs and preferences.

8. Infection Prevention and Control

- Animals must not enter food preparation areas or clinical rooms.

- Hand hygiene must be practiced before and after contact with animals.
- Any animal waste must be cleaned promptly and disposed of safely.
- Residents with compromised immune systems may be restricted from direct animal contact depending on risk assessment.

9. Safeguarding, Health, and Safety

- Aggressive or poorly controlled animals will not be permitted.
- Residents' rights to refuse interaction with animals must be respected.
- Any incidents involving bites, scratches, or allergic reactions must be recorded and reported.
- Pets or animals must not compromise fire safety, security, or emergency evacuation procedures.

10. Training and Awareness

- Staff will be trained in safe handling of animals and infection control measures.
- Residents and families will be informed of the rules and responsibilities regarding pets and animals.

11. Monitoring and Review

- The Registered Manager will regularly review risk assessments relating to animals.
- Feedback from residents, families, and staff will be considered in improving practice.
- The policy will be reviewed annually or sooner if required by regulation or incident.

12. References

- Animal Welfare Act 2006
- Health and Social Care Act 2008 (Regulated Activities) Regulations 2014
- CQC Fundamental Standards – Regulation 12 (Safe Care and Treatment)
- Public Health England / UKHSA Infection Prevention and Control Guidance

13. Related Policies

- Infection Prevention & Control Policy
- Health and Safety Policy
- Risk Assessment Policy
- Safeguarding Adults Policy
- Privacy and Dignity Policy

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